CONTENT SYSTEMS.AI

The peak invoice check

6 lines to check on every carrier and 3PL invoice from now to January. About 30 minutes a week, with last week's invoice and your rate agreements open side by side.

Why this peak is different

Q4 GROUND RATE

Record

Projected ground price per package this quarter, an all-time high on the index.[1]

FUEL SURCHARGE RISE

72 in 100

Of the increase since 2021 came from carrier pricing, not diesel.[1]

1 BACK INVOICE

$200K

Sent to 1 clothing brand by its old fulfillment provider.[2]

1 TD Cowen and AFS Freight Index via Supply Chain Dive, Oct 16 2026, supplychaindive.com/news/fedex-ups-delivery-prices-set-for-record-high-q4/832992
2 Supply Chain Dive, Oct 20 2026, supplychaindive.com/news/bluffworks-targets-lower-fulfillment-costs-after-provider-switch/833337

How to use it

STEP 1

Pull last week's carrier invoice and your 3PL bill. Start with your 20 most common shipments.

STEP 2

For each line, put the charge next to what you agreed. The comparison is on pages 2 and 3.

STEP 3

Write the dollars found, dispute what's wrong, and total it on page 4.

More orders, more lines, less time to read them.

The 6 lines

Each line shows what to compare, where to find it, and the red flag that says you're paying for something you didn't agree to.

☐ 01 Fuel surcharge

$ FOUND _____

COMPARE
The fuel rate applied to each shipment vs the carrier's published fuel table for that ship week.

WHERE TO FIND IT
Invoice detail by tracking number, the carrier's weekly fuel table, your agreement's fuel terms.

RED FLAG
Fuel charged on fees your agreement says are excluded, or a rate that doesn't match the week it shipped.

☐ 02 Home delivery and area fees

$ FOUND _____

COMPARE
Shipments billed as home deliveries vs business addresses. Remote area fees vs the carrier's current zip code list.

WHERE TO FIND IT
Invoice detail, your order export with ship-to company names, the carrier's area list.

RED FLAG
A store, office or warehouse address carrying a home delivery fee. A zip that isn't on the list.

☐ 03 Address corrections

$ FOUND _____

COMPARE
Correction fees vs addresses the carrier actually changed. Was the original address wrong at all?

WHERE TO FIND IT
Correction lines on the invoice, the address on the label, your checkout's address check.

RED FLAG
Corrections on addresses your checkout already verified, or the same address corrected again and again.

Where to look first: the lines that repeat on every order. A small wrong fee on your bestseller is worth more than a big 1 that happened once.

☐ 04 Billed box size

$ FOUND _____

COMPARE
The box size the carrier billed vs the box you actually ship. Big, light boxes are billed by size, not weight.

WHERE TO FIND IT
Billed dimensions on the invoice, your packing spec per product, a tape measure on 3 real parcels.

RED FLAG
A billed size bigger than any box you use. 1 wrong size repeats on every order of that product.

☐ 05 Storage and peak fees

$ FOUND _____

COMPARE
Your 3PL's peak surcharges and storage lines vs the contract: the dates they start, the rate, what they apply to.

WHERE TO FIND IT
The 3PL contract and its peak addendum, the storage report, your stock on hand by week.

RED FLAG
Peak fees before the contract date, or storage billed on stock that already shipped.

☐ 06 Double and late charges

$ FOUND _____

COMPARE
Each tracking number against every invoice this quarter. It should appear once. Then check how old each charge is.

WHERE TO FIND IT
All invoices this quarter in 1 sheet, sorted by tracking number, plus your agreement's billing terms.

RED FLAG
The same package billed twice, or a charge for shipments from months ago.

How to dispute a line

Send 1 short note per problem, not per parcel: the invoice number, the tracking numbers, the charge, what it should be, and the line in your agreement that says so. Attach your proof.

Check your agreement for the dispute window and send inside it. Carriers and 3PLs usually set a time limit. Log every claim and its answer, so the same error doesn't slip through next week.

Ask for the detail, not the summary

A PDF total can't be checked. Ask your carrier and your 3PL for invoice detail as a spreadsheet, 1 row per shipment or per charge. It's the only way to sort by tracking number, compare box sizes and spot a fee that shouldn't be there.

Your weekly total

Fill this in after the checks. Then multiply by the weeks left until January. That's what peak could cost you if nobody reads the invoice.

LINE	SHIPMENTS CHECKED	$ FOUND
01 · Fuel surcharge		
02 · Home delivery and area fees		
03 · Address corrections		
04 · Billed box size		
05 · Storage and peak fees		
06 · Double and late charges		
Total found this week		
× weeks to January = your peak exposure		

Checking every line by hand takes hours a week, right when your team has the least time. So most teams check once, find something, and never check again.

Want every line checked, every week, without the spreadsheet?

Content Systems.ai helps e-commerce brands and 3PLs check every carrier and warehouse charge against what they agreed, so mistakes are caught the week they happen. Your team approves every dispute before it's sent. Try the hidden cost calculator, then get a free quote with your top AI opportunities.

contentsystems.ai/ecommerce